

Carolingian Renaissance

After being crowned Holy Roman Emperor in 800, the French king Charlemagne (768–814) gathered scholars to his court, aiming to revive the glory of the Roman Empire in his lands. He extended his territory from Italy to the North Sea and from the Elbe River to the English Channel, seeking to unite its population under Christianity. Newly commissioned translations of the Bible were illuminated in colourful manuscripts. Influenced by early Christian, Byzantine, Greek and Roman art, but modified by new ideas, these included the Lorsch Gospels and the Utrecht Psalter.

Charlemagne's revival of Christian art became called the Carolingian Renaissance. His enthusiastic patronage attracted some of the most significant intellectuals and artists of the time to his court. The influence of Roman and Byzantine architecture can be seen in Carolingian buildings, particularly the Palatine Chapel built for Charlemagne's court at Aachen in western Germany. Similar influences can be seen in the detailed and intensely coloured mosaics and manuscript covers.



Lothair Crystal, c.860 CE